

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 7 — “The Line in the Ash”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom. Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screen-tone ash. Approx. 22 pages.

PAGE 1

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (*wide, full-width top*) The Wastes at a dead hour. Cracked earth stretches to nothing. Three broken pillars lean in the far distance like the ribs of something long dead. The sky is pale and empty — not bright, not dark. No sun. *No dialogue.* SFX (thin, small): . . .

Panel 2 (*narrow horizontal, center*) Ground-level. Fine gray ash drifts across a split in the earth. A single dry weed trembles though there is no visible wind yet. *No dialogue.* SFX: fwsss

Panel 3 (*wide, bottom*) Two seated figures far apart in the frame, small against the emptiness. EGRIS sits with his back to a fallen stone, his damaged spear laid across his knees. SURO sits a few paces off, cross-legged, sword upright and sheathed in his hands, blindfold facing the open waste. Neither looks at the other. *No dialogue.*

PAGE 2

Panels: 4 (*silent page — no dialogue anywhere*)

Panel 1 Close on SURO’s head. His blindfold. His jaw tenses — a single, small movement. He has heard something.

Panel 2 Close on SURO’s hand where it rests on the sheath. His fingers curl — not drawing, just *listening* through the grip.

Panel 3 Extreme close on his ear. A single line of ink to suggest a vibration reaching him. SFX (faint, far): . . .tk. . .tk. (*a rhythm — footsteps, or something planted and pulled*)

Panel 4 (*wide, bottom — negative space heavy*) Pull back. SURO has turned his covered face toward the horizon. EGRIS has not moved and does not notice. The gap of empty ash between the two men fills most of the panel.

PAGE 3

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (*large*) SURO speaks without turning his head. His posture is perfectly still. SURO: “Someone is walking toward us.”

Panel 2 EGRIS opens his eyes. He does not startle. He looks at Suro, not the horizon. EGRIS: “One?”

Panel 3 (*narrow*) SURO, listening. SURO: “One. Heavy. Iron on leather. He is not trying to hide.” SURO: “He plants something in the ground every few steps. Then pulls it free.”

PAGE 4

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (*large, top*) EGRIS rises. Slow, economical. He does not lift the spear yet — it stays in his loose hand, tip down. His weathered robes hang heavy. His wild hair moves slightly as the wind finally reaches them. EGRIS: “A man who wants to be seen coming.”

Panel 2 (*wide, bottom — the reveal build*) Far shot down the length of the Wastes. A single silhouette has appeared between the broken pillars, distorted by drifting ash. Tall. Broad. A long pole in his grip. SFX (closer now): **tk**. . . **tk**. NARRATION (small box, lower corner): *He came alone. In the Wastes, that is either arrogance or discipline.*

PAGE 5

Panels: 1 (*FULL-PAGE SPLASH — page-turn reveal*)

The FORMER RIVAL, mid-stride, planting his glaive into the cracked earth as he stops. Shaved head, the single thin braid at the back caught in the wind. The scar crosses his brow and the bridge of his nose. Repaired lamellar armor — rectangular plates, tight-wrapped belts, some plates cracked and re-laced. His divided commander’s cloak splits down the center and lifts in two halves on the wind, like a torn banner. His face is calm. Unreadable. He is looking directly at Egris across the distance. SFX (heavy, planted): **DOMM**. *No dialogue.*

PAGE 6

Panels: 4

Panel 1 Close on EGRIS's face. Recognition — immediate, quiet, complicated. Not fear. Not joy. Something older than both. *No dialogue.*

Panel 2 Close on the FORMER RIVAL's hands folded over the top of his planted glaive. Old scars across the knuckles. The grip-wrap worn pale. *No dialogue.*

Panel 3 SURO, still seated, head tilted a fraction. He can hear the tension change in Egris's breathing. SURO (*low*): "You know him."

Panel 4 (*wide*) EGRIS, not taking his eyes off the newcomer. EGRIS: "I buried men because of him." EGRIS: "He buried more because of me."

PAGE 7

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (*wide*) The FORMER RIVAL speaks. He has not moved from his glaive. His voice is level — a man used to being obeyed without raising it. FORMER RIVAL: "You look the same. Older. Poorer." FORMER RIVAL: "I heard a rumor in the dark that the man who took three cities had gone to the Wastes to sit in the dust."

Panel 2 EGRIS, dry, without warmth or heat. EGRIS: "You came a long way to confirm a rumor."

Panel 3 (*narrow, tight on the Rival's eyes — scar prominent*) FORMER RIVAL: "I came because the rumor was true." FORMER RIVAL: "And because true things, out here, tend to get people killed."

PAGE 8

Panels: 4

Panel 1 The FORMER RIVAL finally lifts his glaive from the earth, but only to rest it against his shoulder — a soldier at ease, not a threat. FORMER RIVAL: "Do you feel it? The ground here."

Panel 2 (*ground-level detail*) A crack in the ash-earth. Thin as a hair. As we watch, it lengthens a finger's width. SFX (tiny): **krk**

Panel 3 FORMER RIVAL, gesturing outward at the whole horizon with his chin. FORMER RIVAL: "The Wastes were always empty. A between-place. Nothing chose to stay." FORMER RIVAL: "Now things are gathering. Abandoned souls with no gate to walk through. Eyes from Heaven, watching a man who will not look up. Hunters from below, smelling a throat that hasn't been claimed."

Panel 4 (*wide, heavy shadow*) FORMER RIVAL: “They are gathering because of you, Egris. Because you refused both hands that were offered. Refusal makes a hole. And holes fill.”

PAGE 9

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (*large*) EGRIS, planting his spear now — mirroring the Rival’s earlier gesture, a small deliberate echo. EGRIS: “So this is what you’ve become. A messenger.”

Panel 2 FORMER RIVAL — the first flicker of something under the calm. Not anger. Old grief. FORMER RIVAL: “I am what I have always been. A man who counts the dead and would prefer fewer of them.”

Panel 3 (*narrow*) FORMER RIVAL: “You could stop this. Choose a side and let its strength close the hole. Or impose your own order here, and make rules the gathering things must obey.” FORMER RIVAL: “Either way — structure. Structure is the only mercy the weak ever actually receive.”

PAGE 10

Panels: 4

Panel 1 EGRIS, flat. EGRIS: “Heaven would have me kneel and call it purpose. Hell would have me kneel and call it power.” EGRIS: “You would have me build a throne and call it mercy.”

Panel 2 FORMER RIVAL, unbothered. FORMER RIVAL: “Would that be worse than the dust?”

Panel 3 (*tight two-shot, facing*) EGRIS: “I have worn a crown. I know exactly what it costs the people under it.” EGRIS: “I will not make anyone kneel to me. Not to save them. Especially not to save them.”

Panel 4 (*wide, silent beat*) The two men, spear and glaive planted, ash moving between them. Neither yields an inch of posture. SURO’s seated form small at the edge of the frame, listening to both. *No dialogue.*

PAGE 11

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (*large*) SURO speaks. He still has not stood. This makes his words land harder. SURO: “You are both very sure.”

Panel 2 SURO turns his blindfolded face toward EGRIS. SURO: “Egris. Refusing a throne is not the same as being safe from one.” SURO: “You say you will not make people kneel. But you already decide who lives near you, who eats, who is protected. You call it choice. To them it may already feel like a crown.”

Panel 3 (*narrow, tight on Egris*) EGRIS says nothing. His jaw tightens. The words have found something.

PAGE 12

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (*large*) SURO turns toward the FORMER RIVAL now — impartial, cutting the same way in both directions. SURO: “And you, commander. You speak of order as if it were clean.”

Panel 2 FORMER RIVAL regards the blind man with new attention — reassessing him as a threat for the first time. SURO: “Order built so the weak will not suffer is a fine sentence. But you enforce it with a glaive. The weak learn the order first as fear. Then they call the fear peace, because the alternative is worse.” SURO: “Fear that keeps its promises is still fear.”

Panel 3 (*narrow*) FORMER RIVAL, quiet — not defeated, but honest. FORMER RIVAL: “Yes.” FORMER RIVAL: “I have never pretended otherwise. That is the difference between me and the two hands that offered themselves to your friend. I know what I am asking people to swallow.”

PAGE 13

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (*large, top*) The FORMER RIVAL steps closer to EGRIS — one deliberate stride. Not aggression. Intimacy of old enemies. FORMER RIVAL: “You always thought your restraint made you clean. It didn’t. It just made the cost land on other people instead of on you.”

Panel 2 (*large, bottom — hold on Egris’s face*) Close on EGRIS. For the first time in the chapter, he is visibly unsettled. His eyes move — a man checking whether a thing he’d refused to look at is true. He does not answer. NARRATION (small box): *The worst blows are the ones you cannot honestly return.*

PAGE 14

Panels: 4

Panel 1 SURO's head snaps a fraction to the side. Alert. Different alert — not the Rival this time. SURO (*low, uncertain*): "...Someone else."

Panel 2 EGRIS's left hand. The black vein-like Reaper's Mark. It darkens — the lines crawling a hair further up his wrist. SFX (under skin, felt not heard): *thd... thd...*

Panel 3 (*tight on Egris's face*) EGRIS grimaces, breath catching. He grips his left wrist with his right hand. He does not cry out — but the pain is real. EGRIS (*through teeth*): "...Not now."

Panel 4 (*wide*) SURO has risen at last — the only time this chapter he stands. His head turns slowly, tracking something he cannot place. SURO: "I hear a person. But not their breath. Not their weight." SURO: "As if the ash decided to stand up and watch us."

PAGE 15

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (*large*) The FORMER RIVAL — the man who fears little — has gone completely still. His eyes are fixed on the far horizon, past Egris, past the pillars. Whatever bravado he carried is simply gone. Not fear exactly. Recognition of something that outranks fear. *No dialogue.*

Panel 2 Close on the Rival's scarred face. His grip tightens on the glaive — not to fight. To hold onto something. FORMER RIVAL (*barely audible*): "...I have stood on fields with ten thousand dead." FORMER RIVAL: "I have never felt one presence weigh more than all of them."

Panel 3 (*narrow, silent*) EGRIS, still clutching his marked wrist, slowly turns to follow the Rival's gaze. *No dialogue.*

PAGE 16

Panels: 2 (*silent page*)

Panel 1 (*wide*) The three men, from behind, small in the lower third of the frame. Before them the Wastes open into vast pale emptiness. Ash begins to rise — a storm gathering, sheets of gray lifting off the cracked ground. SFX (rising): *fwooooo*

Panel 2 (*wide, the whole upper frame is storming ash*) Deep in the churning ash, at the very limit of sight, the faintest vertical shape. A standing figure.

Barely a suggestion. The ash bends around it but the figure does not move. *No dialogue.*

PAGE 17

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (*large*) EGRIS, staring. His pain has quieted into something colder — awareness. He has felt this presence before. EGRIS (*quiet*): “She’s been following the mark.”

Panel 2 SURO, tense, admitting the limit of his gift. SURO: “I cannot read her. I cannot read a thing that has no breath and no fear.” SURO: “Egris. What is she?”

Panel 3 (*narrow, EGRIS in profile*) EGRIS: “The one thing out here that serves neither Heaven nor Hell.” EGRIS: “The one that’s actually patient.”

PAGE 18

Panels: 4

Panel 1 The FORMER RIVAL, still not looking away from the horizon, lowers his glaive’s tip to the earth. A soldier’s instinct — do not raise a weapon at what cannot be fought. FORMER RIVAL: “Then my argument is finished.”

Panel 2 EGRIS glances at him, question in his eyes.

Panel 3 (*tight on the Rival*) FORMER RIVAL: “I came to tell you the Wastes are filling with things that will destroy you if you keep refusing.” FORMER RIVAL: “I did not know one of them was already this close.”

Panel 4 (*wide*) FORMER RIVAL: “You do not have as much time to be principled as you think, Egris.” He turns his shaved head toward the distant figure once more. FORMER RIVAL (*softer*): “Neither do I.”

PAGE 19

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (*large — the storm nearly whites out the panel*) The ash storm surges. Visibility collapses. The distant figure is swallowed in gray. SFX: FW000000

Panel 2 (*narrow, the three men bracing, cloaks and robes tearing sideways*) EGRIS shields his eyes. SURO holds his ground. The Rival stands like a planted post. *No dialogue.*

Panel 3 (*narrow, bottom — the storm begins to thin*) The gray starts to fall. Silence returning. SFX (fading): ...fwss...

PAGE 20

Panels: 1 (*near-splash, silent*)

The ash has settled. The horizon is empty again. The pillars. The pale sky. Nothing standing. EGRIS, SURO, and the FORMER RIVAL stare at where the figure was. Three men and an empty distance. *No dialogue.* NARRATION (small box, corner): *For a moment they let themselves believe they had imagined her.*

PAGE 21

Panels: 1 (*FULL-PAGE SPLASH — the page-turn reveal*)

She is not in the distance. The REAPER stands close — impossibly, having crossed the whole Waste in the fall of a page. Long severe black funeral robes. Long locs, utterly still though ash still drifts around everyone else. Her robes do not move at all — the wind does not touch her. She is composed, unhurried, ancient. She is not looking at Egris. She is simply *present*, the way an ending is present in every beginning. Below her, at the level of her open left hand, a single detail is picked out in stark ink: a bead of near-black blood with a deep crimson edge, swelling at her palm, about to fall. SFX: (*none — total silence*)

PAGE 22

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (*extreme close-up — horizontal band across the top*) The REAPER's eyes. Narrow, snake-slit pupils. Calm. Not cruel. Not kind. Reading Egris the way one reads the last line of a page. *No dialogue.*

Panel 2 (*center — the detail shot, high contrast*) The single drop of near-black crimson blood falls from her palm and strikes the pale ash. It does not splash. The ash simply drinks it, a dark stain spreading in a perfect small circle. SFX (the only sound on the page, tiny): **tp**.

Panel 3 (*wide, bottom — she is turned slightly away already, as if she has finished what she came to confirm*) The REAPER speaks. Quiet. Even. Final. REAPER: "You spent your whole life refusing to kneel." REAPER: "Keep walking, Egris. Every road you choose that is not theirs — I will be at the end of it, waiting to see what you were for."

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left throughout. Panel 1 sits at the top-right of each page.
- **The two planted weapons** (Egris's spear, Rival's glaive) are a deliberate visual rhyme — frame them at matching heights in Pages 9–10 to show two equals, not a hero and a villain.
- **Suro stands only once** (Page 14). Save it. His standing is an event.
- **The Reaper's stillness** is the horror device — everything around her (ash, cloaks, hair) moves; she and her locs never do. Never draw her mid-motion.
- **Do not glow the Mark.** Pages 14 — the pain is internal, shown through Egris's body and the crawling vein lines only. No light, no aura.
- **The gut-punch line** is Page 13, Panel 1 ("It just made the cost land on other people instead of on you."). Give Egris a full silent panel to receive it (Page 13, Panel 2). Do not let him answer.
- **Page-turn reveals** are built at: Page 4→5 (Rival's splash) and Page 20→21 (Reaper's splash). Keep the left-hand page (in reading order, the page you turn FROM) quiet so the turn lands.